

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE TELLINGS CUT

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 2 OF SIX

The Emperor Has Lost His Security Deposit

Turn-based strategy, cards and role-playing

Forty real games. Aiden has made it everybody's problem.

Adult comic edition: reclaimed in-group language, profanity, fictional cocaine references and sexual innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan's creative direction.

Tellings Cut 2.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

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A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 2. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P041	P042	P043	P044	P045	P046	P047	P048
2. Ready for conversation	P049	P050	P051	P052	P053	P054	P055	P056
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P057	P058	P059	P060	P061	P062	P063	P064
4. Here for the atmosphere	P065	P066	P067	P068	P069	P070	P071	P072
5. Open to a wildcard	P073	P074	P075	P076	P077	P078	P079	P080

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

They Charged Extra for the Throne

“Nigga, get out of that chair.” I had returned from the suite feeling loved, handsome, and capable of running a small civilization. Tank intended to challenge two of those conclusions immediately. He stood beside a large mechanical recliner covered in white upholstery. The rental company called it a photo throne. I called it a command center. Shawna called it the reason the service corridor was blocked.

I sat anyway. It made a low electrical noise. Somewhere beneath my ass a motor woke up and reconsidered the evening. Tank took one step back. Nigga had instincts honed by years of standing near my ideas. The chair remained upright for the moment. I took this as a sign of loyalty and put my feet on the little platform.

The second game room was supposed to be quieter. People could sit with strategic choices, stories, cards, and imaginary empires. I had therefore decorated it like the headquarters of a man who planned to invade another hotel. Two flags, a projection of stars, the throne, and a velvet rope around chairs that were exactly the same as the chairs outside the rope. The hotel manager looked in, saw me seated, and wrote something down. That nigga's pen had become a predator.

Shawna came over and kissed the top of my head. “We had a nice time upstairs.” “Exceptional,” I said. “Then preserve it by not becoming an emperor.” I told her I could rule gently. She looked at the foot platform. “You can't even get down without help.” I stood to demonstrate. The platform wobbled. Tank caught my elbow with the bored competence of a man who had already budgeted for this.

Mercedes was reviewing her live recording with Porsche. She wanted to hear the quiet parts without me announcing that the quiet parts were excellent. Rosa was settling the additional staff time. She wanted numbers to arrive in the right accounts instead of merely being praised for their importance. Tank wanted to sit, eat, and beat me at something sufficiently clear that I couldn't rewrite the result afterward. Everybody had an objective. Mine required the largest piece of furniture.

Dre came in carrying his casserole dish. A grown man with a blue shirt, an easy laugh, and no interest in auditioning for my themed militia. He was a Crip; this detail did not make him responsible for my blue lighting package. “That controller's mine,” he said, pointing at the blue one. I nodded. His claim was easier to understand than the rental agreement for my throne. Tank offered him a plate. A useful alliance formed without an anthem.

Darnell followed, talking about his yacht to somebody who was not following. He had already been told where his cocaine bag wasn't welcome. Now he wanted to explain that a luxury weekend should have freedom. Mercedes looked up. “Then free me from this conversation.” He laughed as though she was flirting. She wasn't. Porsche moved a chair into the gap between them and asked Mercedes a question about the recording. That was the end of Darnell's audience. The nigga wandered toward a bartender who at least got paid to remain polite.

I wanted to announce that turn-based games meant everybody could relax. Shawna stopped me before I reached the microphone. “Say what you actually know.” I knew some actions waited. I also knew menus could pile up, systems could demand memory, and a counter could make a person feel pressed even when no seconds were ticking away. Tank nodded toward my bills. “Like that. Your debt waits. Ain't relaxing.”

So the useful notes stayed plain. What looked appealing, what a person would do, what might be a pain in the ass. Nobody had to love a heavy strategy game merely because its battles politely waited to make them miserable. Equally, nobody had to avoid a large story if learning it felt good. A grown adult could decide that for herself without me running a ceremonial checkpoint on the way to the chair.

Rosa moved a plate onto the table. Mercedes turned the speaker down enough for conversation. Shawna chose a seat that let her touch my knee without facing the throne. Tank put the first game on and looked at me. "Ready?" I reached for my commanding voice. Then I saw four people waiting for one answer and gave them one. "Yeah, my nigga." The game began. Behind us the empty throne adjusted itself with a small mechanical sigh, possibly relieved to be free of command.

P041 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Sid Meier's Civilization VI

Edition considered: PC base game, no expansion requirement

Build a civilization whose cities, discoveries, and relationships reflect your decisions, gradually creating a history with a direction of your own.

What you do. Found a city, choose its production or research, and manage units, districts, policies, and relationships with neighboring powers over successive turns.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Solo turns allow deliberation, but menus and planning are heavy; test map gestures and readability rather than assuming cognitive simplicity.

Why it might click. Build a civilization across a large sweep of history, choosing how cities grow, what people research and how to deal with neighboring powers. The appeal is seeing many small decisions create a society with a recognizable direction rather than following one prescribed storyline.

The full catch. District placement, research, policies, diplomacy and multiple units produce heavy menu and planning demands. Single-player turns permit deliberation, but this is emphatically not cognitively simple because it is turn-based. Avoid assuming online turn settings match solo play; held map gestures and interface readability still need a trial.

Try this first. Use the guided opening or a modest single-player start to found one city and make one production choice. Judge whether the explanations make that decision interesting before opening an empire's worth of additional responsibilities.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Civilization Has One City and Six Bars

I founded my first Civilization VI city and announced that everybody would prosper. Rosa asked why our real party had six drink stations and nowhere for the catering staff to sit.

“Entertainment infrastructure.” “Nigga, chairs.”

Tank looked over the map while Shawna looked over the room. Both could identify an expensive settlement without enough planning. I tried naming a district after my wife. She said the honor could begin with carrying two chairs.

Mercedes wanted to see what research changed. I wanted to explain my long-term vision. She selected the next thing while I was still describing the horizon.

The game could wait between decisions. My mouth apparently couldn't. Tank put his hand on my shoulder. “Let the nigga ruling the city think.” “That's me.” “Then let everybody else experience it for a second.”

I moved the chairs. My real civilization achieved its first measurable improvement. Nobody constructed a monument, which seemed ungrateful but affordable.

Aiden's verdict. Explore the empire if managing it sounds enjoyable; turns create thinking time, not fewer decisions, as demonstrated by my civilization's urgent and entirely avoidable chair crisis.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact base-game PC listing supports districts, research, policies and diplomacy. Waits refers to single-player turn decisions; complete input comfort and multiplayer timer/co-op configurations are not verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/289070/>

P042 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Old World

Edition considered: PC base game

Guide a historical dynasty where aging rulers, competing families, and personal events give empire management a continuing story about people.

What you do. Read a ruler's decision, consider its personal consequences, and manage cities, resources, character roles, and court relationships as the dynasty develops.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Untimed input is declared, but cities and family relationships form a dense strategy game; co-op setup needs separate checking.

Why it might click. Old World combines historical strategy with a living dynasty: rulers age, families compete, children grow and personal events affect the state. People and relationships can give empire management a more intimate story than a map of anonymous production totals.

The full catch. The developer declares play without timed input, a mouse-only option and saving at any time. That is encouraging for pacing, while court relationships, cities, resources and character roles still make this a dense strategy game. Declared co-op exists, but its setup and shared responsibilities require a separate check.

Try this first. Follow the introductory guidance until one ruler faces one clear decision. Read the affected person's name and consequence, then decide whether that personal layer makes the surrounding management enjoyable or merely adds another spreadsheet to remember.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Dynasty Has Seen My Dating History

Old World let a ruler's family complicate politics. Shawna heard that and immediately asked whether my pretend dynasty knew what I'd paid for our wedding fireworks.

"Nigga, that was romance." "One rocket spelled your name." "So you'd know who loved you."

Mercedes nearly spilled her drink. Tank asked whether a heir inherited the invoices or just the ability to explain them badly. I tried discussing succession. Rosa said the first succession should put somebody else in charge of dessert quantities.

The game's families had ambitions of their own. My friends understood that quickly. I kept acting surprised when an imaginary relation wanted something besides a framed photograph of the ruler. Shawna leaned close. "You want to build a lasting house?" I nodded. She moved the water pitcher within my reach. "Start by noticing who's thirsty."

I poured. Nigga, the great dynasty survived its first administrative reform without requiring a crown-shaped ice bucket.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the family politics if they interest you, with the management load understood; our dynasty currently measures a ruler's promise by whether he can refill glasses.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact listing supports dynasties/families and declares no timed input, Mouse Only Option, Save Anytime and co-op. Those declarations do not establish low menu load or a personally comfortable multiplayer arrangement.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/597180/>

P043 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

HUMANKIND

Edition considered: PC base game

Combine cultures across historical eras, shaping a civilization whose cities, conflicts, and achievements reflect an accumulating series of different choices.

What you do. Choose developments, manage resources and diplomacy, and make battlefield decisions while adapting the civilization to changes across successive historical eras.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Empire and battlefield systems overlap, making memory demands high; solo turns do not establish relaxed settings in every configuration.

Why it might click. Shape a civilization by combining cultures across eras rather than staying with a single identity throughout history. City growth, fame and tactical conflicts turn the map into an account of accumulated decisions, including choices about what kind of achievements matter.

The full catch. Empire management and battlefield decisions sit on top of one another. Culture transitions add systems to learn, while resources, diplomacy and competing goals make the memory load high. Turn-based battles do not establish a universally simple control scheme or relaxed multiplayer timer settings; begin with solo play and inspect menus.

Try this first. Follow the early guidance through one development choice and read what it changes. Stop to decide whether comparing those possibilities feels engaging before treating the next historical era as an obligation to keep playing.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Changed Cultures and Kept the Same Bar Tab

HUMANKIND let me imagine remaking a civilization across eras. I changed my jacket for the second room and called it a new cultural phase.

Tank looked at the hotel bill protruding from my pocket. “Old civilization followed you, nigga.”

Mercedes wanted to compare what a choice might change. I wanted the group to admire my new lapels. Shawna admired them, which encouraged me to turn slowly until I caught the chair with my heel.

Rosa saved the glass. Tank saved nothing; he was laughing too hard to qualify as emergency personnel.

The game offered more interesting questions than whether a man could reinvent himself by removing velvet. What should a society achieve? What did another era make possible? My wife considered my emerging era of Sitting Down a particularly promising development.

I sat. The jacket looked excellent against the chair. Mercedes made a decision on the screen and let its consequences be more interesting than the clothes I wore while watching.

Aiden’s verdict. Try shaping a civilization across changing eras if the choices appeal; my personal cultural transition has retained the debt but substantially reduced the amount of standing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports combining cultures, fame and turn-based tactical battles. Pacing label applies to solo strategic decisions; complete holds, map controls and multiplayer configurations remain unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1124300/>

P044 / A PLACE TO START

Into the Breach

Edition considered: PC Advanced Edition update

Solve small mech battles by reading enemy attacks in advance, finding a move that changes several threats through clever positioning.

What you do. Inspect the next announced attack, identify threatened squares, and move or act with a mech to change what will happen.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The small board still demands spatial reasoning and limited-action planning; selection controls need testing, and failure changes a run.

Why it might click. Small mech battles become visible tactical puzzles because enemy attacks are telegraphed before the next turn. The pleasure is finding an unexpected move that changes several threats at once, often by shifting positions rather than simply choosing the strongest attack.

The full catch. A compact board can still ask for demanding spatial reasoning. Protecting buildings, understanding attack direction and managing limited actions are central, and failure changes a run. The turn structure supports thought before acting; it does not prove every menu or selection gesture suits the player. Advanced Edition adds more systems.

Try this first. Try the opening guidance and inspect one announced enemy attack before choosing a move. Say which square is threatened and what one action changes; there is no need to solve the entire campaign to test that central pleasure.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mech Cannot Save My Shrimp Tower

Into the Breach showed where an attack would land. Our waiter showed exactly where he needed to carry a towering tray of shrimp. I moved the wrong chair anyway.

“Left,” Shawna said. I moved right. Tank grabbed the chair before the waiter acquired a tactical disaster.

“Nigga, you had the whole attack preview.”

At the screen, Mercedes considered pushing an enemy instead of simply hitting it harder. I admired that. In the room she applied the same principle by moving me six feet away from the food route.

Rosa watched one careful move change several problems. “That,” she said, “is satisfying.” I offered to improve the furniture formation. “Stay pushed,” Mercedes said.

The turn waited while we talked. Nobody needed a countdown to appreciate the puzzle. My attention finally stayed on the screen long enough to see the little solution form.

Tank handed me a shrimp. A strategic reward, probably. Also a useful way of keeping my mouth occupied.

Aiden’s verdict. The small visible tactical problem may be inviting if you enjoy planning; our buffet has adopted the same principle by clearly marking where I should not stand.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes minimalistic turn-based combat with telegraphed attacks; current PC includes Advanced Edition content. Waits reflects tactical decision structure, not a complete no-hold/comfort certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/590380/>

P045 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wargroove

Edition considered: PC base game

Lead a displaced queen's bright fantasy campaign, using distinctive commanders and varied terrain to make positioning and resource choices matter.

What you do. Follow campaign instructions, select units on the map, and choose movement or attacks while managing funds and different army roles.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Army funds and unit matchups require learning; exact co-op coverage, timing settings, and selection gestures need their own check.

Why it might click. Wargroove gives turn-based army battles a bright fantasy cast and a campaign about a displaced queen seeking allies. Commanders have distinctive special abilities, while different units and terrain make each map a problem about positioning and resource choices.

The full catch. Managing an army, its funds and its unit matchups is more involved than moving one character. The editor and multiplayer add separate layers rather than simplifying the campaign. Co-op is listed, but exact campaign coverage and setup should be checked; no untimed or hold-free claim applies automatically to every configuration.

Try this first. Start with the campaign's opening instruction and command one unit through one explained action. Test the map selection interface and the clarity of the unit information before recruiting a large army or opening the editor.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Queen Has Taken My Best Chair

Wargroove had a displaced queen seeking allies. Shawna wanted the comfortable chair I'd reserved for myself. I told her it was the command seat.

She sat down. "Command something from over there."

Tank offered to recognize her government for a plate of ribs. Mercedes demanded a competent sound system. Rosa wanted the catering balance paid. Nigga, the coalition formed in seconds and none of its terms mentioned me.

I stood beside the screen and tried to advise the campaign. Shawna chose her own move. I reached for the chair arm; she caught my hand and pulled me close enough for a kiss.

"Still allied?" she asked. "Deeply." "Then stop hovering."

The bright fantasy battles could have their own commanders and terrain. Our local conflict ended with me fetching water for the queen and taking the ordinary seat beside her.

Tank inspected it. "Nigga got diplomatic seating." I said nothing. I was still enjoying the treaty.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the colorful campaign if tactical positioning appeals; my local monarchy has been settled peacefully, with affection intact and my former command chair under new ownership.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports turn-based campaign, commander Grooves and native co-op categories. Co-op mode scope is not assumed to cover the whole main campaign; complete input demands are unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/607050/>

P046 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wargroove 2

Edition considered: PC base game

Return to colorful army tactics through linked campaigns, new commanders, and a conflict over forbidden technology in an expanding fantasy world.

What you do. Read a commander's ability, move units, and use battlefield actions while learning the revised Groove system through the initial campaign.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. New abilities add knowledge to army management; extra modes and listed co-op do not automatically simplify campaign play.

Why it might click. The sequel builds a new conflict around forbidden technology and several connected campaigns, with new commanders and a revised Groove system. Its attraction is returning to colorful map tactics with fresh factions, tactical possibilities and a continuing fantasy world.

The full catch. New commander abilities and linked campaigns add knowledge to the familiar army-management demands. The separate Conquest mode and editing tools are optional avenues, not recommended first steps here. Native co-op is listed, but campaign coverage, timing settings and comfortable selection controls need their own verification.

Try this first. Take the initial campaign instruction one action at a time and read one commander's ability carefully. Compare that single mechanic with ordinary movement before exploring extra modes or designing an ambitious custom scenario for everyone else.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Forbidden Technology Is My Second Fog Machine

Wargroove 2 mentioned forbidden technology. Tank immediately pointed at a crate beside the stage. "Tell me that ain't another fog machine."

"It was a package." "Nigga, so is a box of regrets."

Mercedes read the rental label and called the technician before I could propose a controlled demonstration. He confirmed it was unused. She arranged collection. A technologically advanced civilization had apparently invented the return journey.

Onscreen, new commanders and tactical possibilities were a reason to investigate the sequel. In the room, the sequel to my first mistake needed cancellation before it developed a third act.

Shawna slipped a finger beneath my collar. "You promised less atmosphere." "I thought you meant emotional." "I meant anything that needs ventilation."

The collection crew arrived. I helped carry the crate, which Tank described as my first successful deployment of forbidden technology. Nigga filmed it like a historic disarmament agreement and sent the clip to nobody without asking.

Aiden's verdict. New campaigns may attract anyone who likes these map battles; my own sequel has been revised to remove the unnecessary machine before it acquires a plot.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Current publisher listing supports three campaigns, revised Grooves, Conquest and native co-op. Waits refers to turn-based tactics, not an all-modes or hold-free guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1346020/>

P047 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Advance Wars 1+2: Re-Boot Camp

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch compilation

Explore rebuilt Advance Wars campaigns where colorful commanding officers and land, sea, and air units turn terrain into a tactical puzzle.

What you do. Follow training, inspect a unit's information, and choose movement, capture, or attack decisions while managing different battlefield roles and funds.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Ranges, funds, and mission conditions still demand planning; versus multiplayer does not establish a shared campaign or comfortable controls.

Why it might click. This Switch collection rebuilds the first two Advance Wars campaigns around colorful land, sea and air battles. Commanding officers bring personalities and special powers, while terrain, capture decisions and different unit roles provide a board-game-like tactical focus.

The full catch. Bright presentation does not remove the need to compare ranges, terrain, funds and matchups. It is turn-based, but particular mission conditions can still create strategic urgency. Nintendo's listed multiplayer includes versus play; do not assume a shared campaign. Hold behavior and readability require a check on the actual display.

Try this first. Follow the early training and move one unit using its displayed information. Check whether the explanation makes its purpose clear before progressing to a larger force with several different roles to remember at once.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Boot Camp Has Rejected My Dress Shoes

Advance Wars put colorful land, sea, and air units in front of us. I lined up three serving trolleys to explain combined operations. Rosa took two back immediately.

"Nigga, those got dinner on them." "Military logistics." "Catering. Older institution."

Tank climbed onto the remaining trolley. It rolled six inches, enough to make him step off with dignity he had not earned. Shawna asked whether our demonstration could now end before a hotel worker had to write about it.

At the screen, unit roles and terrain actually changed the choices. Mercedes looked at the map instead of our improvised parade. I tried to give an officer's briefing until she asked which game mode we were discussing. I had to check.

The best thing about having competent friends was the small number of ambulances required by my ideas. The worst thing was how often those friends wanted the exact answer.

Tank returned the last trolley. Boot camp released us without honors.

Aiden's verdict. The rebuilt campaigns offer clear-looking tactical maps but still require learning their rules; our trolley brigade has returned to the much more useful business of serving dinner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo identifies the Switch remake collection and turn-based land/sea/air tactics, terrain and CO powers. Versus multiplayer is confirmed; native campaign co-op is not established. No complete no-hold guarantee.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/advance-wars-1-plus-2-re-boot-camp-switch/>

P048 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Fire Emblem: Three Houses

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Choose a house of characters to know over a long story, where relationships develop alongside tactical battles and a continent's political crisis.

What you do. Talk with the cast, manage lessons and equipment, explore the monastery, and command units through tactical battles in the chosen house's story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Normal/Casual reduces losses, but schedules and menus remain heavy; monastery movement adds a separate camera-control question.

Why it might click. A teacher's relationship with students develops alongside tactical battles and a continent's political crisis. Choosing a house gives the long story a particular group to know, making friendships, loyalties and changing circumstances a substantial part of the experience.

The full catch. Normal difficulty with Casual mode revives fallen allies after battles, but it does not remove lessons, schedules, equipment or tactical menus. Monastery exploration adds three-dimensional movement and camera considerations. This is a rich character game with heavy management demands, not a simple visual novel because conversations are prominent.

Try this first. Choose Normal and Casual for the first trial, then assess one introductory battle explanation and one conversation. Test monastery movement separately when available; comfort with selecting a battle square does not answer the camera question.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Three Houses and None of Them Is My Penthouse

Fire Emblem: Three Houses made me propose dividing the party into factions. Shawna asked whether mine would include people willing to hear my speeches. I said obviously.

Tank looked around. "Small house, nigga."

Mercedes wanted to choose based on the people and the story. Rosa asked how much there was to remember between battles. Both questions improved the evening more than the sashes I had already ordered.

I held up a blue one. Tank shook his head. "Don't bring the Crips into your seating chart." "It's an academy color." "Then graduate from carrying it around."

We put the sashes away. The game could offer its students, loyalties, and political troubles without turning the actual adults in our room into recruits for my organization.

Shawna kept one sash and looped it loosely around my wrist. "For identifying the man who owes me a dance."

I followed. At last, a faction with compelling membership benefits and a very short orientation.

Aiden's verdict. Let a house's people attract you, while keeping the many systems visible; our real factions have dissolved into friends who can choose their own chairs and partners.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms turn-based battles, academy exploration/calendar and Normal/Casual options. Casual removes permanent allied losses in battle, not other complexity. Whole-path hold/camera comfort remains untested.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-gb/Games/Nintendo-Switch-games/Fire-Emblem-Three-Houses-1175482.html>

P049 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Fire Emblem Engage

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Experiment with character and Emblem pairings in colorful tactical battles, discovering how different strengths change the options available on the grid.

What you do. Read unit matchups, select battle actions, and develop characters through weapons, rings, skills, and pairings with legendary Emblems as the campaign progresses.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Normal/Casual and other aids change punishment or support decisions; they do not establish low menu load or comfortable hub movement.

Why it might click. Engage emphasizes colorful tactical battles and the abilities gained by pairing characters with legendary Emblems. The appeal is experimenting with a cast's different strengths and seeing how a chosen pairing changes the possibilities on a grid-based battlefield.

The full catch. Weapon relationships, rings, skills and party development create many interlocking rules. Nintendo confirms Normal difficulty, Casual mode and Auto-Battle, plus a limited rewind system. Those aids change punishment or decision support; they do not prove low menu load or comfortable movement around the hub.

Try this first. Use Normal and Casual, read one unit's weapon matchup, and try its basic action before exploring every ring combination. Examine Auto-Battle as an optional tool only after seeing what it controls, keeping the choice to participate or delegate yours.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Ring Has Heard Enough About My Legendary Power

Fire Emblem Engage made me point at my wedding ring and claim I too possessed a legendary bond that improved all my abilities.

Shawna looked at the wine I'd spilled on my cuff. "Accuracy still needs work."

Tank asked whether marrying twice equipped a second power. Rosa turned toward him slowly. "You planning an experiment?" "Nigga, theoretical research." He offered her the best chair before the proposal reached peer review.

Mercedes liked looking at how different pairings changed a battle. I liked looking at my wife, which she noticed and encouraged by stretching out her hand for me to kiss. For one graceful second I had the whole room beat.

Then I caught my sleeve on her bracelet. Two legendary adults stood joined at the wrist while Porsche patiently freed the clasp.

The game could manage its own powerful combinations. Our party had identified a simpler one: jewelry, vanity, and a woman willing to laugh while helping me disentangle the evidence.

Aiden's verdict. Pairing characters and Emblems may be entertaining if the tactical systems appeal; my marital enhancement remains powerful but has not yet unlocked competent sleeve management.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo supports grid tactics, Emblem pairings, Normal/Casual, Auto-Battle and limited rewind. No full-path hold/camera assurance or shared campaign is inferred; multiplayer scope remains unverified here.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-gb/Games/Nintendo-Switch-games/Fire-Emblem-Engage-2267157.html>

P050 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Join Mario characters and Rabbids in comic tactical battles, where their different roles make cover, positioning, and coordinated attacks worth learning.

What you do. Follow a solo battle explanation, compare movement with an attack, and learn exploration, equipment, and abilities as the adventure continues.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Local co-op covers separate challenges, not the full campaign; navigation and controls need checking without assuming the sequel's accommodations.

Why it might click. Mario characters and Rabbids join forces in colorful tactical battles, with each hero contributing a different role. The mismatch between earnest adventure and Rabbid behavior offers a comic frame for learning positioning, cover and coordinated attacks.

The full catch. Combat takes turns, but exploration, equipment and abilities still require learning and navigation. Nintendo describes local co-op as additional challenges, not the entire story campaign. Do not infer the sequel's hold toggles or other accommodations for this first game; exact gesture and camera comfort need checking.

Try this first. Follow an early solo battle explanation and compare one movement option with one attack. If playing together is the main attraction, inspect the separate co-op challenges and their requirements rather than promising shared control of the whole campaign.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Rabbids Did Not Order Those Suits

Mario and the Rabbids appeared just as three hired hosts arrived in matching white jackets. I had asked for “playful elegance.” They looked like a dental conference about to rob a yacht.

Mercedes stared at me. “Nigga, did you hire your own minions?” One host said he'd been promised actual duties. Rosa immediately found useful things for all three to carry.

At the screen, different characters could work together rather than merely stand around matching. Tank asked which modes let people do what together. I started answering from the picture. Shawna handed me the actual notes before I invented a feature.

We checked. I stopped trying to put every form of togetherness under the same label.

The hosts returned with fresh water and cleared plates. They had become competent members of the party by taking direction from Rosa. I asked whether they liked their jackets.

One said they were hot. Nigga, the first honest review of my elegance had arrived.

Aiden's verdict. The comic tactical mismatch may be fun if the systems suit you; check the separate co-op mode, and leave my matching-jacket theory of teamwork at the door.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms turn-based combat and separate local co-op challenges. Co-op flag is restricted to those challenges; no whole-campaign co-op or Sparks of Hope control options are transferred.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/mario-plus-rabbids-kingdom-battle-switch/>

Source 2: <https://play.nintendo.com/news-tips/game-releases/mario-rabbids-kingdom-battle-release-date/>

The Emperor Required a Sewing Kit

The noise came when I bent to retrieve my phone. A small, direct sound, followed by a breeze where no breeze had been invited. Tank looked up from his plate. Shawna closed her eyes. Mercedes asked whether that was the chair. I remained bent over for one tragic second, because returning upright would mean accepting what had happened. “Tailoring,” I said. “Minor issue.” Tank stood behind me with a tablecloth. “Nigga, you got a diplomatic opening.” He wrapped the cloth around my waist while Rosa sent a hotel worker for a sewing kit. Nobody screamed. Nobody died. Several people nearly choked laughing, but they had brought that on themselves by witnessing history without adequate preparation.

Shawna took my hand and led me toward the dressing room. I tried to make the journey look sensual. She said I looked like a man escorting a banquet table into retirement. From behind us Tank called, “Keep the cloth, my nigga. We can rent it as a skirt.” Mercedes asked him not to put that idea anywhere a sponsor could hear it.

In the dressing room my wife inspected the damage. “You bought these too tight.” “For the silhouette.” “The silhouette has escaped.” She handed me a hotel robe and told me to change while she checked the seam. I said she seemed remarkably calm around a husband in his underwear. “Aiden, we just spent private time together. This isn't a press preview.” I had to sit down because laughing made the remaining seam threaten solidarity.

There was a knock. Darnell wanted to know if we needed anything to keep the party going. Shawna answered through the door. “A tailor.” He offered to call somebody from his yacht. “A tailor who's here, nigga,” she said. Silence. Then Rosa arrived with the kit, a pair of spare black trousers from the costume rack, and the news that the caterers had been paid correctly. She was having a much more successful evening than I was, and she deserved every inch of it.

The spare trousers fitted except for the length. Shawna turned the hems under while I stood still. “There's my emperor,” she said. “Finally following instructions.” I touched her shoulder. “You know I'm grateful.” “I do. You don't always have to build a stage so I can hear it.” For a moment the room got quiet in a way I liked. Then Tank called through the door to ask whether the tablecloth was formally retiring from food service. Romance requires friends with good fucking timing, and I had none.

When I came back, Mercedes had the new recording playing softly through one speaker. Porsche was listening to a passage they wanted to compare. Dre and Tank were looking at a small game together. Rosa sat with both feet under her chair instead of working on them. Nobody had needed my replacement announcement. The room had kept going while its emperor borrowed trousers.

I looked at the velvet rope, still dividing identical chairs. Unhooked it. Rolled it up. Tank watched without making a joke, which was kind until he said, “Careful bending, nigga.” I straightened my knees and coiled the rest standing up. Shawna returned to her seat beside me. The cloth went to the laundry. The throne remained empty. My dignity recovered enough to accept dinner without requesting a new title.

P051 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Mario + Rabbids Sparks of Hope

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Travel between imaginative planets with Mario and the Rabbids, combining heroes with Sparks while their antics give each new place comic appeal.

What you do. Explore with direct movement, inspect control options, and choose hero abilities or battle actions while learning how movement-based techniques work.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Useful control options exist, but camera, direct movement, and traversal still need testing; the first game's co-op does not transfer.

Why it might click. Mario and the Rabbids travel between imaginative planets, meeting odd characters and combining heroes with helpful Sparks. Tactical battles sit inside a larger exploratory adventure, with the cast's antics providing a light comic reason to see what the next place contains.

The full catch. Ubisoft documents specific hold toggles, single-press alternatives, camera adjustments, automatic skill management and invulnerability. These are real options, not proof of a wholly no-rush path: direct movement, camera handling and airborne or traversal actions need checking. The first game's co-op challenges do not establish co-op here.

Try this first. Inspect those control options before play, then test ordinary movement and a first battle at the preferred difficulty. Check how a team jump or other moving action feels when introduced; stop there if the practical demands outweigh the appeal.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Hope Has a Settings Menu and I Don't

Sparks of Hope made me promise a trip between planets. Shawna asked whether we could first move between the ballroom and our suite without six people stopping me to discuss lighting.

Mercedes inspected the actual settings described in the notes. I watched her find practical possibilities I'd almost buried beneath a speech about cosmic wonder.

"Nigga, help looks like this," she said, pointing. Tank pointed at the chair I was blocking. "Also like moving."

I moved. Rosa tried a small bit of navigation and said exactly what she'd want to check next. Nobody answered with the phrase you'll get used to it. I had been about to, but Shawna's hand on my knee arrived before my mouth could damage the atmosphere.

"Different kind of spark," I whispered. She laughed. "Focus, husband."

We let the game keep its planets and the settings keep their real value. My contribution was finally small enough to fit the room we were actually in.

Aiden's verdict. Explore the colorful journey if its tested settings help, while checking movement for yourself; the most useful spark I supplied tonight was occasionally paying attention.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer UX interview documents listed options and time to think during turns; publisher article confirms direct real-time movement. These do not verify every traversal sequence. Single-player sequel assessed separately from Kingdom Battle.

Source 1:

<https://news.ubisoft.com/en-gb/article/3geL8IbYETmgHk6W017HpS/mario-rabbids-sparks-of-hope-accessibility-spotlight>

Source 2: <https://news.ubisoft.com/en-us/article/65J7B5ga4HkMpXtYWQ7QX5>

P052 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

XCOM: Enemy Unknown

Edition considered: PC base game; not Enemy Within expansion

Build Earth's defense against an alien invasion, growing attached to soldiers whose battlefield decisions connect to research, equipment, and headquarters planning.

What you do. Move soldiers into cover, choose explained combat actions, and manage research, budgets, equipment, and base decisions between ground missions.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Multiple soldiers and base systems add weight; casualties create pressure, and complete interception or held-input behavior is not audited.

Why it might click. Lead a defense organization against an alien invasion, growing attached to soldiers while choosing research, equipment and battlefield tactics. The appeal is the connection between a strategic headquarters and the small, consequential decisions made by a squad on the ground.

The full catch. Turn-based ground combat still involves cover, ranges, hit chances and multiple soldiers. Research, budgets and base decisions add another layer, while casualties and global threats create pressure. This card is Enemy Unknown without assuming Enemy Within additions; complete interception, timing and held-input behavior has not been audited.

Try this first. Use the opening tutorial and focus on one soldier's move into cover and one explained action. Assess whether the battlefield information feels interesting before treating the larger base-management system as part of an evening's commitment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Aliens Want a Better Soundcheck

XCOM: Enemy Unknown gave me a defense headquarters. The hotel gave Mercedes a feedback squeal from a speaker. I announced that I would locate the hostile signal.

The sound technician reached past me and adjusted one control. Silence. Nigga, apparently Earth had hired somebody qualified.

Tank wanted to name a soldier after me. Shawna asked whether that meant the soldier would sprint ahead of the plan and demand better lighting. I said real leadership involved risk. Mercedes said real leadership could begin by letting the technician work.

The game tied people, equipment, and decisions together in a way that made consequences matter. My proposed organization had excellent uniforms and no idea what any cable did.

I carried a spare stand to the correct place. The technician thanked me. It felt disturbingly good to receive approval for doing the requested thing.

Tank still named the soldier after me. "Don't get him killed," I said. "Then stop giving him advice, nigga."

Aiden's verdict. Building a defense team can be compelling if the management appeals; my fictional namesake deserves a commander who reads the situation before volunteering somebody else's bravery.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Base-game listing supports turn-based squad combat, base/research management and interceptions. Pacing is mixed because the full strategic/interception loop is not certified wholly untimed. No expansion feature is assumed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/200510/>

P053 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

XCOM 2

Edition considered: PC base game; not War of the Chosen expansion

Lead a resistance under alien occupation, developing soldiers whose ambushes, successes, and losses become the history of a mobile organization.

What you do. Inspect cover and movement boundaries, choose soldiers' actions, and manage the base, skills, and mission objectives across the resistance campaign.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Turn limits create urgency; camera operations, held-Control waypoint paths, and permanent casualties add demands in the base game.

Why it might click. The sequel turns Earth's defenders into an insurgent force, building a mobile organization and conducting tactical missions under alien occupation. Ambushes, soldier development and the changing campaign give each squad's successes and losses a continuing personal history.

The full catch. Turn limits create strategic urgency without requiring a fast mouse click. The manual also describes many action controls, camera operations and a held Control-key gesture for waypoint paths. Base management, skill trees and permanent casualties add weight. This is the base game; expansion options for changing timers are not assumed.

Try this first. Leave the tutorial enabled and inspect one soldier's movement boundary and cover information. Read a turn-limited objective literally when it appears, then decide whether pressure measured in decisions is acceptable even when the decision itself can be considered.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P053 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

XCOM 2

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Resistance Has Lost the Hotel Wi-Fi

XCOM 2 put us under alien occupation. A login screen put us outside the hotel's internet. I described both as oppressive systems and demanded a strategic response.

Shawna entered the room number. Connected. "Liberated, nigga."

Tank liked the idea of a mobile resistance headquarters. He suggested our drinks trolley, which already carried supplies and avoided my speeches. Rosa refused to let anybody repurpose it until dinner was finished.

The game's missions had their own pressure, including objectives measured in turns. I started calling that the same as no pressure. Mercedes shook her head. "People can think slowly and still dislike a deadline."

I looked at the notes again. That was fair. My own deadline involved paying an extension before the room closed; the fact that the manager waited patiently did not make him relaxing.

We chose whether the game sounded worth that tension. I stopped comparing the Wi-Fi portal to an invasion and successfully resisted buying another router.

Aiden's verdict. The resistance story may justify the layered tactics for you; turn limits still matter, and our hotel occupation ended with a room number rather than guerrilla brilliance.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports base-game premise; official port manual documents turn-based actions, turn timers, casualties and held Control for waypoint movement. Waits concerns tactical decisions, not absence of turn pressure. No War of the Chosen options transferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/268500/>

Source 2: <https://www.feralinteractive.com/en/manuals/xcom2/latest/steam/>

P054 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Invisible, Inc.

Edition considered: PC base game

Plan corporate infiltrations where different agents and equipment make one well-chosen action open an unexpected path through security toward a valuable escape.

What you do. Inspect guards and sight lines, use agent abilities or hacking resources, and plan an extraction while choosing actions across successive turns.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The alarm rises each turn, so thinking time does not remove pressure; abilities and extraction plans require substantial tracking.

Why it might click. Corporate espionage becomes a tactical puzzle about agents, security systems and getting out with something valuable. Different operatives and equipment combinations let a plan feel clever when a small, well-chosen action opens an unexpected route through trouble.

The full catch. The designer describes an alarm that rises at the end of each turn. Thinking time is available, but escalating consequences can still feel urgent. Agent abilities, hacking resources, sight lines and extraction plans create heavy demands. Custom modes exist, yet a specific no-pressure configuration has not been established here.

Try this first. Try the introductory mission and inspect a guard's attention and one available agent action. Watch what changes when the turn ends, then judge the alarm's emotional effect rather than deciding solely from the absence of a seconds countdown.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Invisible Except for the Sequins

Invisible, Inc. inspired me to retrieve the sponsor's new introduction without him noticing. I wore a sequined jacket that threw light across the room every time I breathed.

Mercedes watched me approach. "Nigga, the chandelier can see you."

Tank volunteered to distract the sponsor by asking about his yacht. This worked immediately and catastrophically: the man began showing forty photographs. Tank looked over after the first ten with the expression of an operative whose extraction window had closed.

Shawna simply asked for the introduction. The sponsor handed it over. She returned it to Mercedes, who removed the unwanted sales pitch.

The game could make sneaking through corporate security feel clever. Our actual operation required one direct question and a friend willing to say no. I went to rescue Tank.

The sponsor showed me the yacht bathroom. Tank escaped while I looked. Nigga had used me as cover. At last somebody in our espionage unit understood his equipment.

Aiden's verdict. A careful infiltration puzzle may reward planning if its alarm pressure appeals; my sequined stealth deployment succeeded only after I was reclassified as a large reflective distraction.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports stealth systems/custom modes; first-person designer article explains alarm advancement per turn. No particular alarm-removal setting or full input accommodation is inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/243970/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamedeveloper.com/design/game-design-deep-dive-alarm-systems-in-klei-s-i-invisible-inc-i->

P055 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Shadowrun Returns

Edition considered: PC original release

Follow a murder investigation through Seattle's mix of magic, cybernetics, and corporate power, with a team whose different abilities support the job.

What you do. Read conversations, choose a starting archetype, and direct team actions in tactical battles while managing attributes, equipment, spells, and other abilities.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reading and character systems are substantial; turn-based fights do not certify every mission demand or held gesture on the full path.

Why it might click. A murder investigation moves through a Seattle where cybernetics, magic and corporate power collide. The story offers an adult genre mixture, while turn-based team combat lets different kinds of characters contribute practical abilities to the same job.

The full catch. Character creation, attributes, equipment, spells and tactical positioning are substantial systems. The game also relies on considerable reading, so a mystery-led premise does not make it a simple detective interface. Turn-based fights allow consideration, but the complete mission path and every held gesture have not been independently tested.

Try this first. Pick one clear starting archetype and follow the first conversation before studying every possible build. In the first instructed battle, learn one basic action and one support option rather than trying to master magic, drones and hacking together.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mage Can't Fix the Payment Terminal

Shadowrun Returns put magic beside technology, and Rosa asked whether our hotel could adopt the combination. The card terminal had stopped responding while the manager insisted it was perfectly functional.

"Then function at it," she said.

I offered to cast something. Shawna gave me a look. Tank said, "Nigga, your last spell was asking the room to make you sexy. It opened the bill."

Mercedes wanted the murder investigation and the mixed crew, not another demonstration of my spiritual Wi-Fi. We settled around the screen while the manager fetched a different terminal.

The setting let unlike talents belong to the same job. I liked that. In our room, Rosa knew what she was owed, the technician knew the equipment, and Tank could identify food through a closed lid. I was still looking for my class.

Shawna leaned against me. "Occasionally useful husband." I chose it immediately. The advancement opportunities sounded excellent, and I already owned the necessary ring.

Aiden's verdict. The adult magic-and-corporate mystery may be worth its tactical menus; my chosen character class currently requires helping without announcing that a miracle has occurred.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes Seattle murder investigation, classless development and single-player turn-based tactical RPG. Waits refers to combat decisions; no complete no-hold or low-complexity certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/234650/>

P056 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Shadowrun: Dragonfall - Director's Cut

Edition considered: PC Director's Cut

Meet a Berlin crew with distinct histories and difficult loyalties, where relationships offer a substantial reward for learning Shadowrun's tactical systems.

What you do. Talk with the team, follow the first job, and choose tactical actions using character roles, equipment, and abilities across the campaign.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. This remains a reading-heavy tactical RPG; redesigned menus do not establish simplicity or settle every late mission's input demands.

Why it might click. Dragonfall brings Shadowrun's magic-and-technology world to Berlin and centers a crew with distinct personalities and histories. The Director's Cut expands the campaign and team material, making relationships and difficult loyalties a substantial reward for learning its tactical systems.

The full catch. This remains a reading-heavy tactical RPG with character builds, equipment and team abilities. Its redesigned interface is not evidence that menus are few or self-explanatory. The standalone Director's Cut differs from the earlier expansion; complete timing, held gestures and late mission demands have not been verified here.

Try this first. Meet the initial team and try a small portion of its first job, focusing on one character's role. Decide whether the conversations make you want to know these people before planning an optimized build or committing to every side mission.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Berlin Has Rejected My Crew Nicknames

Dragonfall gave us a crew with histories. I gave our friends new code names. Mercedes was The Voice. Tank was The Wall. Rosa was The Provider. Shawna was already leaving the conversation.

"Nigga, we got names," Tank said.

I explained that code names strengthened loyalty. Mercedes asked if The Provider had been paid. Rosa held up her phone. "She has now." That was a better origin story than mine.

The game's relationships worked because the people had reasons to remain themselves, not merely useful roles in somebody else's speech. Porsche chose a seat and asked about a character's past. We followed that instead of my naming ceremony.

Shawna returned with drinks. "What's your code name?" "The Legend." "The Leg End," Tank said, pointing at the sock exposed above my shoe. "Your trousers short, nigga."

I tugged them down and sat. The crew stayed loyal, apparently, but absolutely nobody agreed to maintain the dignity of command.

Aiden's verdict. If a developed crew and difficult loyalties appeal, Dragonfall offers reasons to learn its systems; our own crew has voted unanimously to keep its original names.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact Director's Cut page confirms standalone identity, Berlin, expanded missions/team material and revised combat/interface. No all-path timing/hold guarantee; mature themes include explicit violence and difficult backstories.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/300550/>

P057 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Shadowrun: Hong Kong - Extended Edition

Edition considered: PC Extended Edition

Explore a dense Hong Kong urban-fantasy setting with a developed crew and corporate intrigue, plus an additional campaign in the Extended Edition.

What you do. Read crew conversations, manage characters and inventory, and alternate tactical team encounters with the game's separate Matrix interactions during the campaign.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Matrix stealth and timed code or symbol elements prevent assuming the whole game waits; a comfortable complete route is unverified.

Why it might click. The third standalone Shadowrun adventure offers a dense urban fantasy setting, a developed crew and corporate intrigue in Hong Kong. Its Extended Edition includes the later bonus campaign, giving players who enjoy the characters more story beyond the original ending.

The full catch. Do not treat the whole game as unhurried because combat takes turns. Its Matrix has stealth and timed code/symbol-matching elements reported in gameplay documentation. A comfortable way through all required instances has not been verified. Text, character builds and inventory management are also heavy; this is a deliberate story-focused detour.

Try this first. Assess an early crew conversation and the character interface, then investigate the Matrix requirements before committing to the campaign. If someone offers help, agree which operations they would handle instead of quietly assuming every later obstacle will disappear.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P057 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Shadowrun: Hong Kong - Extended Edition

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Matrix Has Asked Me to Stop Guessing

Shadowrun: Hong Kong made the digital world look dangerous and complicated. My hotel television made entering a six-character access code look like a hostage negotiation.

I typed it wrong twice. Tank read the card. “That's a zero, nigga.” “Could be an O.” “Then ask it how it feels.”

Mercedes reminded us that this game's interface changes mattered; the Matrix sections weren't automatically comfortable just because other encounters used turns. I had nearly waved the distinction away with a grand statement about taking our time.

Shawna pointed at the actual catch. We left it where a reader could see it. No speech transformed it into a feature.

The television finally connected. On the screen, the crew and city still looked interesting. On my face, the expression of a man defeating a complex network concealed that he had simply copied the correct character.

Tank applauded once. “Hackerman.” Nigga made one clap sound like an entire review.

Aiden's verdict. Keep the rich setting available as a deliberate detour, with the Matrix demands clear; my own hacking career remains limited to reading the card correctly.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Extended Edition publisher page confirms revised Matrix and bonus campaign. Community gameplay documentation describes timed Matrix minigames; full-path alternatives are unverified, so no untimed completion is promised.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/346940/>

Source 2: <https://shadowrun-series.fandom.com/wiki/Matrix>

P058 / A PLACE TO START

Wildermyth

Edition considered: PC base game

Watch ordinary heroes acquire relationships, transformations, and lasting histories, creating a tactical adventure partly discovered through the consequences of your choices.

What you do. Meet the heroes, choose event responses, and direct battle actions while developing abilities and relationships; shared play can divide hero control.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Evolving characters and tactics require attention; injury and aging matter, and co-op still needs agreement about controls and decisions.

Why it might click. A band of initially ordinary heroes develops through tactical adventures, personal events and relationships. Characters can transform and carry their histories forward, giving the player a story that feels partly discovered through consequences rather than entirely delivered by a fixed cast.

The full catch. Tactical positioning, abilities, event choices and evolving characters all require attention. Injury, sacrifice and aging are part of the story. Native cooperative play can divide hero control, but setup and shared decisions still need agreement; it is not automatic simplification. Every input and late sequence has not been audited.

Try this first. Begin an introductory campaign and meet the first heroes before judging their long-term builds. Try one event choice and one battle action. If sharing play, agree who controls which hero and whether advice is invited.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Legend Came Back With a Different Haircut

Wildermyth let ordinary people acquire extraordinary histories. I said this described me perfectly. Mercedes asked which portion of my history involved ordinary behavior.

“Before fame.” “Before breakfast?” Tank offered.

Rosa liked that people could change through what happened to them. Shawna liked relationships carrying forward. I liked any system that might remember my achievements without needing me to announce them at dinner.

Porsche found a photograph from an earlier party where I had the same confident pose and an appalling haircut. She put it beside the screen. “Your legacy.”

“Nigga, that was a transition.” “Into what?” I had no response strong enough for the fringe.

The game could turn consequences into a shared story. Our group had been doing that for years, usually against my preferred version. Shawna kissed the side of my head and said the current haircut was much better.

Tank asked if we could recruit the old one as a monster. History is fucking cruel.

Aiden’s verdict. A company whose people change may be appealing, especially if shared play interests you; my personal legacy has survived everything except an accurately dated photograph.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports evolving heroes, tactical battles, difficulty choices and cooperative campaign play with separately controlled heroes. Memory rating is editorial; co-op does not guarantee reduced burden or complete input comfort.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/763890/>

P059 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Wartales

Edition considered: PC base game

Build a medieval company's survival story through contracts, camp life, skills, and equipment, with native co-op offering a way to share it.

What you do. Inspect party and camp menus, choose contracts, manage supplies and equipment, and use professions alongside tactical battles and world exploration.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Some professions use timed minigames; avoiding them throughout a chosen route is unverified, and party management is extensive.

Why it might click. Lead a band through a harsh medieval world, choosing contracts and gradually shaping its camp, skills and equipment. The appeal is the practical, emergent story of a company surviving together rather than fulfilling a single hero's destiny; native co-op can share that company.

The full catch. Food, money, gear, professions and tactical battles create extensive management. Some profession activities use timing-based minigames, so turn-based combat does not mean a completely untimed game. A whole-route way around those activities is unverified. Exploration and party maintenance add further demands; this is a marked detour.

Try this first. Inspect an opening party and camp menu before pursuing contracts. Check the specific profession interactions a chosen plan would need, and only then consider a short shared outing with clear agreement about who handles each operation.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mercenaries Want Their Overtime

Wartales made running a company look like a story about food, equipment, and getting paid. Rosa pointed toward the catering crew. “Look, Aiden. Fantasy.”

I tried to make a joke about loyal retainers. She gave me the shift schedule. The hired hosts needed an answer about overtime. They had been carrying things in my ridiculous jackets for hours.

I approved the time before asking for another favor. Tank nodded. “Nigga learning the order.”

The game's mercenary life had appeal precisely because survival came through practical choices. It also had activities we couldn't pretend were all leisurely just because the battles used turns. Mercedes read the catch aloud while I finished the hotel adjustment.

One of the hosts took off his hot jacket with visible relief. Shawna said the crew looked better comfortable anyway. I agreed and resisted explaining how this supported my original vision.

Nigga, sometimes your finest command is letting people remove the thing you bought them.

Aiden's verdict. Company life may be compelling if its demands suit you, but the timing catches keep this a detour; our own mercenaries have secured overtime and breathable clothing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher confirms open-world company management, turn-based combat and up-to-four-player co-op. Gamepressure's profession guide describes timing minigames. Their complete avoidability has not been established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1527950/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamepressure.com/newsroom/professions-in-wartales-explained-list-and-description/zd543a>

P060 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Battle Brothers

Edition considered: PC base game

Lead a mercenary company through a harsh, unscripted world where recruitment, contracts, equipment, and battlefield outcomes create a history you can recognize.

What you do. Inspect recruits and gear, read contracts, travel across the world, and direct turn-based battles while paying wages and managing injuries.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. World travel is real-time while battles use turns; pause behavior needs checking, and harsh consequences accompany extensive management.

Why it might click. A mercenary company develops its own history through recruits, contracts, equipment and battles in a changing world. The appeal is a tough, unscripted campaign where decisions leave marks and a modest success can feel earned because failure remains possible.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly separates real-time world travel from turn-based battles. Roster management, wages, equipment, injuries and risk assessment are substantial. Harsh consequences can produce pressure even when battle decisions wait. Pause behavior during travel and every held-input requirement need checking; this is not a low-management fantasy adventure.

Try this first. Inspect a starting company's people and equipment, then read one contract's terms before accepting anything. Test travel controls and pausing deliberately. If the administrative burden already dominates the fun, another entry deserves the evening instead.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Battle Brothers and the Dinner They Deserve

Battle Brothers offered a mercenary company whose history could get ugly. Tank immediately asked whether I intended to name everybody after our friends and then get offended by consequences.

“Of course not.” Shawna looked at the recruit I'd named AIDEN THE EXCEPTIONAL. “Nigga, we haven't even started.”

I considered the equipment costs. Rosa smiled at the sudden respect entering my face. “Amazing what paying people yourself does for attention.”

The hard campaign interested Mercedes as a place where a little success might matter. It didn't interest everyone equally, and nobody had to join my imaginary battalion to remain welcome at dinner.

Tank renamed one recruit Tank. I asked whether that was vanity. “No. That's somebody who expects armor before a speech.”

I gave him decent gear and a sensible job. Then I moved my own recruit out of the most heroic-looking danger. Shawna squeezed my arm. “Exceptional decision, baby.” For once I accepted a compliment without enlarging it.

Aiden's verdict. Choose this harsh company story only if its complexity and losses sound enjoyable; my recruiting office has finally discovered that adequate equipment outranks an inspiring adjective.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes real-time travel, turn-based combat and mercenary contract/equipment management. Travel pause/hold details are not established here; strategic pressure is an editorial warning, not a seconds-timer claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/365360/>

P061 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

BATTLETECH

Edition considered: PC base game

Command giant combat machines in a mercenary company where personalities, damage, and tactical outcomes continue to matter after the battle ends.

What you do. Inspect a machine's movement and weapons, make battlefield choices, and manage loadouts, repairs, contracts, and the company's equipment between engagements.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Technical menus and economic consequences are substantial; listed competitive multiplayer does not establish a cooperative story campaign.

Why it might click. Command enormous combat machines while managing the mercenary company behind them. The attraction is the connection between personalities, damaged equipment and tactical decisions: a battle's outcome follows the crew back to a traveling base rather than vanishing at a results screen.

The full catch. Weapon loadouts, heat, armor, positioning, repairs and contracts create substantial technical and menu demands. Battles take turns, yet long engagements and economic consequences can still feel taxing. The publisher lists competitive multiplayer and solo skirmishes; do not infer cooperative campaign play from sharing a screen or discussing tactics.

Try this first. Try the opening instruction or a solo skirmish and inspect one machine's movement and weapon choices. Before accepting a company-wide campaign, decide whether reading its equipment information is an enjoyable part of the experience or simply too much administration.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The BattleMech Has a Massage Setting

BATTLETECH's huge machines made me proud of the mechanical throne I'd rented for photographs. Then the chair reclined with me in it and refused to come back up.

Tank bent over my face. "Nigga, your mech got defeated by leisure."

Shawna stood at my feet looking amused enough to end a marriage and attractive enough to restart it. "You comfortable?" "I could use assistance." "You've been asking for that position all evening."

Mercedes turned away laughing while I defended the honor of my upholstery.

The rental man found the control. The chair rose slowly, forcing everyone to watch me return to authority at the speed of an elderly drawbridge.

Onscreen, damaged machines came back with costs that affected their company. Mine came with a technician's fee and a recording Tank promised not to share unless I lied about it.

I immediately decided truth was a valuable principle. Nigga, operational expenses can make a philosopher out of anybody.

Aiden's verdict. The mercenary machines offer a compelling link between people, tactics, and repair bills; my prototype has demonstrated the risks of purchasing command furniture before checking reverse.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports turn-based mech combat, contracts, repairs, company management and solo skirmish/PvP modes. Complete held/camera interactions are not tested; no native co-op inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/637090/>

P062 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

TRIANGLE STRATEGY

Edition considered: PC release

Explore political conflict where allies vote on major choices, making persuasion, scarce resources, and competing principles matter alongside tactical battles.

What you do. Read conversations, consider political choices, and direct units through positional battles while learning their abilities at a comfortable difficulty.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed input and adjustable difficulty support pacing, but dialogue, political names, tactics, and menus still demand substantial attention.

Why it might click. Political conflict, scarce resources and competing principles shape a story in which allies can vote on major choices. Tactical battles and conversations both matter, making the central attraction the tension between personal conviction, persuasion and the needs of a group.

The full catch. The PC listing declares play without timed input, adjustable difficulty and saving at any time. Those features help pacing but do not shrink the dialogue, political names, unit abilities or positional tactics. Expect a heavy reading and menu load; the story's moral weight may itself feel demanding.

Try this first. Choose a comfortable difficulty and follow an early conversation before testing one explained battle action. Pay attention to whether the political questions interest you enough to learn the surrounding systems; no vote of the Bureau can supply that interest.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Vote Says Pay Rosa First

TRIANGLE STRATEGY had people voting over consequential choices. I called a party vote on extending the room, funding the extra performance, or paying the remaining catering adjustment.

Rosa raised her hand. "One of those is already owed." Tank raised both hands. Mercedes asked why my debts had entered an election.

Shawna took the microphone. "We pay Rosa. Then we ask what people actually want." The room approved before I'd explained the voting procedure. Nigga, democracy was happening at an irresponsible speed.

In the game, competing convictions could make persuasion interesting. In our room, I had tried to disguise arithmetic as a moral dilemma because a ballot felt more impressive than opening my bank app.

I paid. Rosa checked. Then she voted to keep a quieter room available for whoever still wanted games. Mercedes seconded it. Tank promised to move the remaining food.

The plan passed without my dramatic tie-breaking intervention. I carried two chairs to feel connected to the constitutional process.

Aiden's verdict. The political decisions may be a strong attraction if the tactical load appeals; our local voting system excludes whether I should pay a bill I've already incurred.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports conviction/voting and tactical systems; current PC metadata declares no timed input, adjustable difficulty and Save Anytime. These are declarations, not independent full-path control validation.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1850510/>

P063 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Tactics Ogre: Reborn

Edition considered: PC Reborn edition

Follow Denam through factional conflict, where branching decisions connect personal loyalties with public consequences in a sustained tactical political fantasy.

What you do. Read the political situation, direct units through battle turns, and manage a roster's equipment, classes, and abilities as choices branch.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reborn declares untimed input, but rosters and political names require learning; selection and camera comfort still need testing.

Why it might click. Denam's decisions unfold amid factional conflict in a kingdom shaped by past rule and renewed war. Branching story choices and tactical battles make the appeal a sustained political fantasy in which personal loyalties and public consequences rarely stay neatly separate.

The full catch. The current Reborn PC listing declares no timed input, mouse-only and keyboard-only options, and saving at any time. Even so, a large roster, equipment, classes, battle rules and political names demand substantial learning. Reborn's revised systems differ from earlier releases; comfortable selection and camera use still need testing.

Try this first. Read the opening situation and try one unit's basic turn without planning an entire army. Keep a small character note if useful, then decide whether the political intrigue makes the menus feel worthwhile rather than automatically accepting them as a toll.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Rebellion Has My Room Key

Tactics Ogre offered branching loyalties in a kingdom full of conflict. At the hotel, Shawna and Mercedes took our room key and declared the dressing room a territory free of my surprise announcements.

“Nigga, I'm being deposed.” “You're being given a chair,” Rosa said.

Tank considered both sides. My faction had promises. Theirs had dinner and a clear exit route. He crossed over without even pretending to negotiate. An ugly day for hereditary charm.

The game's political choices deserved more attention than my little domestic melodrama. I sat beside Rosa and listened while she considered a character's position. People could want different things without waiting for a hero to assign their motives.

When Shawna returned, she'd changed into shoes she could enjoy. “Miss me?” “Painfully.” “Good. You can dance without conducting a territorial survey.”

She led me out. The rebellion had secured comfortable footwear, privacy, and a husband who finally followed somebody else's route across the floor.

Aiden's verdict. A branching political fantasy may reward sustained attention, with its systems fully acknowledged; our palace revolt has achieved shoes, privacy, and an unexpectedly pleasant peace treaty.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Reborn listing supports branching story, revised tactical systems and developer-declared no timed input/Mouse Only/Keyboard Only/Save Anytime. Complexity assessment is editorial, not a clinical rating.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1451090/>

P064 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

FINAL FANTASY TACTICS - The Ivalice Chronicles

Edition considered: PC Enhanced version proposed for later assessment

Follow Ramza and Delita through Ivalice's struggle over class, power, and loyalty, with fully voiced dialogue in this edition's Enhanced version.

What you do. Choose Enhanced and Squire, then move characters and select battle actions while gradually learning jobs, equipment, and positioning during the story.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Squire lowers a barrier without removing tactical systems; Classic differs, and held-input or camera comfort has not been verified.

Why it might click. Ramza and Delita are drawn through a struggle over power, class and competing loyalties in Ivalice. This edition's Enhanced version adds fully voiced dialogue and refinements, offering a specific modern route into a substantial tactical story rather than an unspecified nostalgic recommendation.

The full catch. Use Enhanced with Squire difficulty for the proposed trial. That lowers a barrier but does not remove job systems, equipment, positioning or a large cast of names. The Classic version has different features. Complete held-input and camera comfort remain unverified, and a gentler setting does not make every battle simple.

Try this first. Select Enhanced and Squire, then follow the opening explanation through one character's movement and action. Read only the abilities immediately available before considering future job combinations; the first question is whether this turn feels understandable and interesting.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Ivalice Has No Place for My Platinum Package

FINAL FANTASY TACTICS brought class, loyalty, and power into our conversation. I had just offered three guests access to my “platinum” area, which was the same room behind a more expensive rope. Mercedes looked at it. “Nigga, the chairs identical.” “The exclusivity isn't.” “Neither is the bullshit.” Tank unhooked the rope because it obstructed Rosa's trolley. An entire social order collapsed under the practical requirements of potato service.

We checked the Enhanced version and the chosen difficulty before starting. Shawna wanted the voiced scenes heard properly. I stopped trying to narrate over them. The game's people had enough to argue about without a hotel aristocrat contributing from the sofa.

The sponsor asked what had happened to the platinum area. Rosa invited him to sit wherever there was space. He did, apparently surviving equality without an ambulance.

I coiled the rope and put it away. Nigga, even my velvet oppression had a restocking fee.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the specified Enhanced edition for this route into the political story; our own class system has been dismantled because its only distinctive feature blocked dinner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Square Enix's current official page confirms exact title, Enhanced/Classic distinction, voiced Enhanced dialogue and Squire difficulty. Job/ability complexity is documented; complete no-hold/camera comfort is not.

Source 1: <https://final-fantasy-tactics-the-ivalice-chronicles.square-enix-games.com/en-us>

P065 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Disgaea 5 Complete

Edition considered: PC Complete edition

Enjoy an extravagant demonic rebellion where huge numbers and unusual combinations make increasingly elaborate systems part of the comedy and attraction.

What you do. Try the opening move-and-act battle loop, then gradually explore jobs, items, special mechanics, and customization if those systems become enjoyable.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The Complete edition adds extensive material and deep systems; turn-based decisions do not make its menu or memory burden light.

Why it might click. Disgaea 5 turns tactical role-playing into an extravagant comic machine of demons, rebellion, huge numbers and unusual combinations. Its appeal is enjoying systems that become increasingly ridiculous, with a cast and world equally happy to push beyond ordinary fantasy restraint.

The full catch. The Complete edition contains extensive added material and many deep systems: jobs, items, special battle mechanics and customization. That is a major menu and memory burden, not a promise of more effortless entertainment. Turn-based decisions help pacing, but the publisher's abundance is exactly the catch for someone wanting few systems.

Try this first. Try only the opening explanation and a basic battle action. Leave bonus scenarios and long-term optimization alone until the fundamental move-and-act loop feels enjoyable; there is no requirement to consume everything included in the word Complete.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Netherworld Has a Two-Drink Minimum

Disgaea 5 made extravagant demonic power look almost modest beside the invoice from my party decorator. I showed Tank the total. He whistled. "Nigga, you unlocked the final boss."

Darnell arrived boasting that his yacht parties used bigger numbers. Mercedes asked whether those numbers came with guests who let other people finish a sentence. He began explaining his premium cocaine. "Still the same sentence," she said, and turned back to the game.

I liked the ridiculous scale until the menus made it clear the systems also expected attention. Shawna read a choice twice. I wisely refrained from saying it was simple.

Tank wanted a demon powerful enough to negotiate the catering minimum. Rosa said her minimum was already reasonable and had survived stronger demons than him.

The game could keep its enormous combinations. We kept one manageable question on the screen. Darnell went to tell the bartender about his yacht, and the bartender charged him for the privilege of remaining nearby.

Aiden's verdict. Embrace this excess if elaborate systems themselves sound fun; our party has confirmed that large numbers are entertaining right up until they appear beside my signature.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Complete listing documents included scenarios, jobs, customization and multiple strategic systems. Waits is tactical decision pacing; no full-path no-hold or low-menu claim is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/803600/>

P066 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Disgaea 7: Vows of the Virtueless

Edition considered: PC base game

Follow a reluctant fighter and enthusiastic client through demonic comic excess, where oversized transformations turn tactical possibilities into increasingly unreasonable spectacle.

What you do. Learn movement and attacks, select targets through PC menus, and explore character classes, items, and special battle mechanics as interest grows.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Systems remain dense, and auto-battle unlocks only after completing each stage; it is not a verified first-pass story bypass.

Why it might click. A reluctant fighter and an enthusiastic client anchor a demonic tactical adventure with exaggerated powers and comic excess. New systems such as oversized combat transformations fit a series whose appeal includes seeing a seemingly sensible strategy become gloriously unreasonable.

The full catch. The PC publisher specifically supports keyboard/mouse menu and target selection, but the many classes, items and mechanics remain dense. Auto-battle unlocks after successfully completing each stage; it is not a verified first-pass story bypass. Turn-based structure does not settle every held-input requirement or make the management light.

Try this first. Learn the first battle's ordinary movement and attack before opening every customization possibility. Test whether the PC menu and target controls feel clear, and judge the cast's humor separately from the attraction of increasingly elaborate numerical combinations.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Giant Demon Cannot Fit Through the Ballroom Door

Disgaea 7's oversized transformations reminded me of the inflatable mascot waiting in its crate. I told the operator to bring it in. He asked about the door width.

"It's a large door." "How large?" Nigga, professionals kept ruining imagination with measurements.

Tank found the dimensions on the label. The thing wouldn't fit. Mercedes asked whether I'd planned to demolish a wall before or after her set. Shawna touched my arm. "Baby, keep one huge thing about yourself imaginary."

I opened my mouth. She smiled. "Choose your response carefully." I closed it. Tank had to leave the room to laugh properly.

The game could make excess part of a complicated tactical playground. My mascot could remain deflated without sacrificing anyone's evening. Rosa used the cleared space for a serving table.

The operator thanked us for canceling before inflation. I paid him and accepted that, in this particular story, refusing to become enormous was my most impressive transformation.

Aiden's verdict. The demonic spectacle belongs with an appetite for its layered systems; my own giant transformation has been canceled because the door and my wife presented persuasive objections.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Base PC listing supports Fuji/Pirilika, Jumbification, keyboard/mouse menu controls and auto-battle unlocked by completed stages. No complete-edition extras, unconditional autoplay or hold-free guarantee is inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2250600/>

P067 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Chained Echoes

Edition considered: PC release

Travel with an ensemble across a war-torn world of dragons and machines, with political trouble and personal stories sustaining the journey.

What you do. Move through the world, read the cast's story, and select turn-based battle actions while learning skills and managing equipment along the way.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The publisher describes complex skills and equipment; directional movement may require holds, and every potential timing question is not settled.

Why it might click. An ensemble crosses a war-torn continent in a fantasy world that mixes dragons and machines with a deliberate older-RPG visual style. The appeal is a long journey through varied places, with character stories and political trouble giving the travels a continuing purpose.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly describes a complex skill and equipment system. Turn-based battles permit choosing actions, while exploration still requires directional movement and may involve sustained inputs. Visible enemies replace random encounters, but that does not eliminate combat, navigation demands or every potential timing question across the whole story.

Try this first. Follow the opening until you can test one movement segment and one explained battle choice. Read the currently useful skill information, then decide whether the cast and world make further systems learning attractive rather than assuming retro-looking graphics mean retro-sized complexity.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Airship Is a Minibus With a Deposit

Chained Echoes mixed dragons and machines, so I asked whether our shuttle could be decorated as an airship. The driver said decoration was extra and wings couldn't extend over the mirrors.

Tank looked at me. "Nigga, people just need a ride home."

Mercedes wanted to follow the ensemble across its world. I wanted our transport to support the theme. Rosa wanted the driver to know who actually needed a ride and when. She made a list while I negotiated imaginary aviation.

Shawna slipped the brochure out of my hand. "Want to take me somewhere?" I said absolutely. She pointed at the dance floor, six steps away and entirely without fuel requirements.

We danced while the driver confirmed the actual route with Rosa. The game kept its large journey. Our party secured the modest miracle of people going where they'd asked to go.

Tank watched us pass. "Look at this nigga finally transporting somebody." I spun my wife gently and let him have the line.

Aiden's verdict. The ensemble journey may justify learning the battles if its world appeals; our local transport now promises correct destinations, which has outperformed the proposed dragon decal.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports story-driven ensemble journey, visible enemies, turn-based battles and complex equipment/skills. Held movement and complete path comfort are unverified; no all-game no-timer claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1229240/>

P068 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Sea of Stars

Edition considered: PC base game

Join companions in a colorful sun-and-moon fantasy adventure, with local cooperative story play available through the Dawn of Equinox update.

What you do. Move through the world, inspect difficulty and relic options, and choose battle actions that include timed hits during the companions' journey.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Timed hits are real, including in co-op; a complete route avoiding every timed or held action has not been established.

Why it might click. A colorful, classically inspired role-playing journey follows Solstice Warriors through a world of sun-and-moon magic. The combination of scenery, companions and adventure is the attraction; the Dawn of Equinox update also makes the story available in local cooperative play.

The full catch. Timed hits are a real combat mechanic, including in co-op. The developer documents difficulty presets and relic adjustments, but this research does not establish a complete path avoiding every timed or held action. Movement and traversal require separate checks. Treat it as a deliberate detour rather than assuming turn-based means entirely unrushed.

Try this first. Inspect the installed version's difficulty and relic explanations, then test movement and one early battle with no expectation of perfect timing. If the required operations already conflict with preferences, enjoy the premise and choose another route without a mastery assignment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Moon Has No Interest in My Pool Speech

Sea of Stars made me suggest moving everyone beside the rooftop pool for celestial atmosphere. Shawna looked at the stairs. Mercedes looked at her equipment. Rosa looked at the food.

“Nigga,” Tank said, “you move the sun.”

We stayed where we were. The screen could provide its scenery without making seven adults carry dinner through a lift. I checked the updated shared-play information and the timing catches before proposing who might join whom.

Dre, our new grown guest in a blue shirt, raised his controller. “This one's still mine.” I respected the claim. He had also brought a casserole, which gave him more material authority than my rented sky projector.

Shawna leaned against me as the game's companions began their journey. “There,” she said. “Stars without moving the room.”

I looked up at my projector, switched off and unnecessary. Nigga, it had cost money to learn that a screen could already display a sky.

Aiden's verdict. The journey may be appealing, including its supported shared play, but timed inputs still need attention; our celestial outing has wisely remained beside the existing chairs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer describes original story with Dawn of Equinox's up-to-three-player local co-op, timed hits and difficulty presets. This assesses that updated base adventure, not the OST or unverified Sunset Edition changes. Complete no-timed/hold path unknown.

Source 1: <https://sabotagestudio.com/press-release/sabotage-studio-announces-free-sea-of-stars-update-dawn-of-equinox-bringing-top-fan-requested-additions-to-pc-and-consoles-gains-november-release-date/>

P069 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

OCTOPATH TRAVELER II

Edition considered: PC release

Choose among eight protagonists with distinct motives, then discover how their different beginnings and an expanding cast relate within one shared world.

What you do. Follow a chosen traveler's opening, select battle actions, and manage jobs, equipment, movement, and character abilities as the wider journey develops.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed input is declared, but eight stories and battle systems add memory load; comfortable directional holds remain a separate question.

Why it might click. Eight protagonists bring separate motivations and talents to a shared world, with stories that can be approached through different beginnings. The attraction is choosing a person who catches your interest, then discovering how an expanding cast and their journeys relate.

The full catch. The PC listing declares play without timed input, but battles still use several interacting systems and the wider journey includes movement, jobs, equipment and distinct character abilities. Remembering eight stories can become substantial. Directional hold comfort remains a separate question even when battle selections wait.

Try this first. Choose one traveler because the premise appeals, read that opening, and learn one ordinary battle action. Keep the next step attached to that character before treating the whole ensemble as a single large list of unfinished obligations.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Eight Travelers and One Nigga Blocking the Door

OCTOPATH TRAVELER II offered eight different beginnings. I offered our guests eight suggested itineraries for the rest of the evening. Mercedes chose a ninth: ignoring mine.

Rosa wanted to finish dinner. Tank wanted another look at a battle. Shawna wanted music. Porsche wanted five quiet minutes. Dre wanted to find the lid for his casserole. Darnell wanted an audience. The bartender wanted Darnell to order something.

Nigga, my room had become an ensemble without consulting its narrator.

I watched the game's distinct people make separate reasons for beginning. Then I stepped out of the actual doorway so my own people could do the same. Nobody needed to form a party behind me whenever I moved.

Shawna came back for my hand. "You coming?" "Where?" "With me, if you want."

A whole night of selling routes, and the best invitation had eight words and no package price. I took her hand. Tank found the casserole lid and achieved a different happy ending.

Aiden's verdict. Pick a protagonist whose motives interest you and let the systems follow at a tolerable pace; our guests have already demonstrated the advantages of choosing their own beginnings.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports eight travelers, Path Actions, jobs and Break/Boost; developer declares no timed input. Mixed label reflects active exploration alongside waiting battle decisions, not a contradicted timer claim. Hold comfort unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1971650/>

P070 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

DRAGON QUEST XI S: Echoes of an Elusive Age - Definitive Edition

Edition considered: PC Definitive Edition

Join an accused hero and growing band of companions in a colorful identity-searching adventure, with both personal backstories and traditional turn-based battles.

What you do. Inspect presentation choices, move through the world, and choose party actions while managing equipment and abilities across a long companion-filled story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The 3D camera, directional holds, and optional minigames need checking; the 2D option is not an instant universal solution.

Why it might click. A young hero accused of being a threat gathers companions and searches for the truth of his identity. The appeal is a substantial, colorful adventure with personal backstories and a traditional turn-based battle structure; this edition also includes a two-dimensional presentation option.

The full catch. Party equipment, abilities, navigation and a long story create a meaningful memory load. The 3D presentation brings camera demands; trying 2D may change that burden but is not a universal solution or instant switch at every moment. Directional holds and optional minigame timing remain separate checks.

Try this first. Inspect the Definitive Edition's presentation choices and begin without extra Draconian challenge settings. Try ordinary movement and one early turn-based battle, judging both the immediate controls and whether the companions' tone makes a long adventure sound inviting.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P070 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

DRAGON QUEST XI S: Echoes of an Elusive Age - Definitive Edition

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Chosen One Has Been Asked to Validate Parking

DRAGON QUEST XI S introduced a hero whose identity brought trouble. The hotel manager introduced me to three guests whose parking needed validating. Recognition had consequences everywhere.

“Nigga, I thought you wanted your name known,” Tank said.

I validated the tickets and came back to a world colorful enough to make my decorations look needlessly literal. Shawna wanted to meet the companions. Rosa asked which presentation we were actually considering. We checked instead of pretending every version worked the same way.

I said I identified with a misunderstood chosen one. Mercedes looked at the tickets in my hand. “Chosen by the valet. Important calling.”

Tank gave me one more. His car had been outside since lunch. I considered protesting, then remembered he'd caught me near a pond, moved three pieces of furniture, and saved my shrimp tower.

The grand adventure could wait while I performed one small quest for my friend. Nigga even gave me directions to the desk.

Aiden's verdict. A long companion-filled adventure may be worth exploring in the specified edition; my chosen-one duties currently include appreciating the friends who keep my evening upright.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact XI S Definitive page confirms 2D/3D modes, companions, turn-based combat and optional Draconian challenges. Mode-switch limits and full input/timing comfort are not fully verified; no original-XI assumptions.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1295510/>

P071 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Persona 5 Royal

Edition considered: PC Royal edition

Spend time with a stylish ensemble whose daily relationships connect to a supernatural struggle against abusive power, supported by striking music and presentation.

What you do. Read conversations, plan calendar choices and relationships, explore dungeons, and select combat actions while following the ensemble's long character story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Required later countdowns and timed traversal conflict with strict no-rush needs; menus, calendar planning, and camera handling add complexity.

Why it might click. A stylish ensemble of students balances daily relationships with a supernatural campaign against abusive power. Royal offers an extensive character story with striking music and presentation, making the desire to spend time with its cast entirely understandable even when its systems are demanding.

The full catch. This is a detour for a strict no-rush preference. Royal walkthroughs document a required later boss with a thirty-minute countdown, alongside timed traversal elsewhere. Ordinary turn-based combat does not erase those exceptions. Calendar choices, relationship planning, combat menus, dungeon movement and camera handling create additional complexity.

Try this first. Judge the opening conversations and presentation, but keep the late countdown warning in the decision from the start. Establish a deliberate shared-viewing or help arrangement before investing in a long campaign if those required operations are unacceptable alone.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P071 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Persona 5 Royal

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Phantom Thief Stole My Schedule

Persona 5 Royal had a stylish group navigating relationships and a packed calendar. I held up our party schedule. Mercedes took it and tore off the section marked UNEXPECTED AIDEN MOMENT.

“How it unexpected if you wrote it down, nigga?” Tank asked.

Shawna wanted the story considered honestly, including the bits that actually used a timer. I read the warning before praising the turn-based combat as though that described every second of the game. The music was attractive enough without me selling away the catch.

Rosa put my remaining schedule beside the plates. “People will do what they want.” “There was a closing toast.” “There was a man who promised to sit down.”

I sat. The calendar in the game could create pressure and possibility. Ours no longer had to.

Mercedes pocketed the torn strip. I asked if she was stealing my moment. “Saving it from you,” she said. Nigga, very efficient phantom work in a visible red dress.

Aiden’s verdict. Keep the characters available as a deliberate detour, with the required timed encounter plainly stated; our real calendar has lost one oppressive event and gained breathing room.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Royal PC listing supports premise. Royal-specific walkthroughs corroborate required Okumura time limits; no PC option removing them was verified. Story interest is separated from full-route suitability.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1687950/>

Source 2: <https://gamefaqs.gamespot.com/ps4/260936-persona-5-royal/faqs/78256/week-24-october-1st-october-9th-okumuras-palace>

Source 3: https://www.neoseeker.com/persona-5-royal/Okumura%27s_Space_Station

P072 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

BRAVELY DEFAULT II

Edition considered: PC release

Travel with four heroes through a crystal-centered fantasy, using a battle rhythm that asks when to save actions and when to commit them.

What you do. Learn an ordinary attack and Default, observe the next turn, and combine jobs, abilities, and equipment as the adventure develops.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed input is declared, but Brave Points and jobs create heavy tactics; directional control may still require uncomfortable holds.

Why it might click. Four heroes undertake a crystal-centered fantasy journey with jobs and abilities that can be combined in different ways. The signature battle idea is deciding when to store action capacity and when to spend it, creating a recognizable rhythm of preparation and commitment.

The full catch. The PC publisher declares play without timed input and adjustable difficulty. That helps pace, while Brave Points, primary and secondary jobs, equipment and enemy behavior still create a heavy tactical load. Exploration requires directional control; a no-timed-input declaration does not establish that movement is comfortable without holds.

Try this first. Choose a comfortable difficulty and learn one ordinary attack and one Default action in the early guidance. Observe what changes on the next turn before planning elaborate job combinations or trying to bank an entire party's future at once.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Saved Three Speeches and Spent Them All at Dinner

BRAVELY DEFAULT II made saving and spending actions sound strategic. I told Shawna I'd saved up three compliments for her and planned to deploy them together.

"Try one that isn't about how lucky I am." Nigga, she had seen my opening hand.

Tank liked the idea of storing something now for a bigger move later. He had done it with dinner rolls and was prepared to demonstrate. Rosa removed the bread basket from his reach before theory became a siege.

At the screen, committing actions involved a real choice rather than simply doing the biggest thing available. I considered that while my wife waited for the first compliment.

"You look like you chose tonight for yourself," I said. "And I'm glad I get to be here." She softened. No joke for a second. Then she kissed me and said the other two could remain in reserve.

Tank whispered, "Nigga finally learned economy." I let him keep his roll.

Aiden's verdict. The store-and-spend rhythm may make battles interesting if you enjoy job systems; my own resources improved dramatically when I stopped spending three sentences on one feeling.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing explains Brave/Default, jobs and four heroes; developer declares no timed input and adjustable difficulty. Mixed pace distinguishes exploration from waiting decisions, not a claim of required timers. Holds untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1446650/>

P073 / A PLACE TO START

Slay the Spire

Edition considered: PC original game

Build a deck from limited choices, enjoying the moment a useful card-and-relic combination gives the next encounter a different shape.

What you do. Read attack and defensive cards, spend available energy, and choose cards or relics that develop a plan across the climb's encounters.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Card effects and energy require reading and planning; test targeting gestures, and expect losing runs as part of the structure.

Why it might click. Build a deck while climbing a changing sequence of encounters, choosing cards and relics that make the next fight play differently. The appeal is recognizing a useful combination and gradually shaping a plan from imperfect, limited choices rather than executing a fixed routine.

The full catch. The developer declares play without timed input, mouse-only play and saving at any time. Card text, energy, status effects and deck interactions still demand reading and planning. Test card selection and targeting for drag or hold comfort; losing a run is part of the structure, not evidence that the trial was wasted.

Try this first. Begin with the first available character and examine one attack card and one defensive card before playing either. Try one encounter and judge whether the tradeoff is satisfying without aiming to finish the entire climb on the first visit.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Spire Doesn't Accept My Guest List

Slay the Spire offered me cards and imperfect choices. I asked Tank whether we could improve my opening selection. He said we could improve many things if I stopped assuming the best option was owed to me.

“Nigga, is this advice or cards?” “Two services. Same friend.”

Mercedes noticed a combination I had missed while admiring the name of a card. Rosa wanted to know what an effect actually did before choosing it. Shawna leaned close enough to distract me and then enjoyed watching me pretend the distraction was tactical.

I built toward one idea instead of taking everything that looked impressive. The deck became more coherent. My party, by comparison, still contained an unemployed fog machine and a gold statue nobody would stand beside voluntarily.

Tank tapped the screen. “You learning.” I started describing my instinct for restraint. He pointed at the next choice.

Nigga had found the perfect counter to my speech: another decision worth thinking about.

Aiden's verdict. Try building combinations if that kind of thinking feels rewarding; my deck may achieve the focused identity that our party lost when I approved decorative marine life.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original PC game listing supports deckbuilding/roguelike structure and declares Mouse Only, no timed input and Save Anytime. Card manipulation comfort and full-path suitability are not independently verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/646570/>

P074 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Monster Train

Edition considered: PC original game

Defend a train through stacked battle spaces, where choosing a creature's floor can matter as much as choosing the next card.

What you do. Place units on floors, play spells, and develop the deck through upgrades while defending the train across an ordinary solo run.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Exclude clock-driven Hell Rush from this trial; floor placement and card effects remain complex, with drag comfort unverified.

Why it might click. Defend a train across stacked battle spaces by combining units, spells and upgrades into a developing deck. The vertical layout changes the familiar card-battle question: where a creature stands can matter as much as which card is played next.

The full catch. Use an ordinary solo run for this proposal. The publisher explicitly describes Hell Rush multiplayer as a real-time, clock-driven competition, so exclude it from a no-rush trial. Multiple floors, unit placement, card upgrades and interacting effects still create a substantial mental load; dragging and held-input behavior require checking.

Try this first. Open a solo run and inspect one unit's placement and one spell before advancing the fight. Keep attention on the immediate floor arrangement; there is no need to plan a perfect deck or enter any competitive challenge to understand the attraction.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Train Has Three Floors and No VIP Rope

Monster Train's stacked battle spaces made me propose a hierarchy for our hotel rooms. Tank asked whether the top floor had better food. Rosa said all the food was downstairs with her.

“Then that's the top, nigga.”

Mercedes considered where a unit belonged rather than merely how impressive it looked. I had put a decorative throne beside the narrowest doorway for exactly the opposite reason. Shawna pointed this out without even leaving her chair.

We checked that we were considering the ordinary solo route rather than the special timed mode. The train had enough to think about without borrowing pressure from somewhere else.

I moved the throne out of the doorway. Two guests passed comfortably, which Tank described as an unprecedented transit victory for my administration. Rosa brought drinks through without turning sideways.

Onscreen, a placement made the next encounter work better. In the room, another placement did the same. Nigga, transportation theory had finally reached my rented furniture.

Aiden's verdict. The vertical card battles may offer satisfying choices; stay clear of the timed mode for this trial, and place the attractive furniture where people can pass it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original-game publisher page supports three vertical fields/deckbuilding and explicitly identifies Hell Rush as timed real-time multiplayer. Waits applies to the proposed ordinary solo mode, not all modes; holds remain unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1102190/>

P075 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Griftlands

Edition considered: PC release

Navigate a rough science-fiction world where separate conversation and combat decks make negotiations, alliances, and grudges matter mechanically as well as narratively.

What you do. Read negotiation or combat cards, choose them in encounters, and manage relationships whose effects can follow the protagonist into later situations.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Two decks and relationship consequences require substantial text and tracking; every gesture or possible timing exception has not been audited.

Why it might click. Three separate protagonists navigate a rough science-fiction world through fights, negotiations and relationships. Maintaining different decks for talking and combat makes social encounters mechanically substantial, while choices about allies and enemies can follow the character into later situations.

The full catch. Two decks, relationship effects, faction loyalties and run-based consequences make this more demanding than a small casual card game. Considerable text explains abilities and social stakes. Turn-based card decisions support deliberation, but no full-path guarantee about every gesture or timing exception has been independently established.

Try this first. Start the opening character's story and read one negotiation card in context before building a grand strategy. Try one exchange, observing both what the card does and why the other person cares, then decide whether managing conversation this way is enjoyable.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Negotiation Deck Is All Apologies

Griftlands made talking and fighting separate kinds of encounters. I asked Shawna which deck I was best at. She said neither and suggested a third deck labeled LISTEN.

The sponsor wanted one more photograph. Mercedes wanted to leave the stage without selling a drink. I offered a compromise in which he stood beside me instead. He looked disappointed. Nigga, I discovered my market value in real time.

Tank watched us negotiate. "Play the card where you stop making promises." I did. The sponsor took a photograph of the room and moved on. Everybody survived the absence of my brilliant settlement.

The game could make relationships and chosen approaches matter in a satisfying way. Our party had done the same with less visible machinery and more snacks.

Shawna took my hand. "Good talk." "I barely spoke." "Exactly." She kissed me before I could spoil my winning play by explaining it. Nigga, the LISTEN deck had excellent rewards.

Aiden's verdict. If relationships changing both conversations and conflicts appeal, investigate this layered card game; my strongest negotiation now consists of an accurate promise followed by a closed mouth.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports three campaigns, separate negotiation/combat decks and persistent social consequences. Waits describes core card decisions; held gestures and complete-path exceptions have not been tested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/601840/>

P076 / A PLACE TO START

Dicey Dungeons

Edition considered: PC release

Enter an absurd dungeon game show as walking dice, turning rolled numbers into equipment effects and small tactical puzzles with lively presentation.

What you do. Read an equipment requirement, assign a rolled die, and observe its effect before choosing another placement or continuing through the dungeon.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Arithmetic and equipment conditions require thought; test placement gestures, and begin with the initial character before learning different rule sets.

Why it might click. Walking dice face a peculiar dungeon game show, turning rolled numbers into attacks and other equipment effects. Different characters change the rules enough to make a familiar-looking die produce very different little tactical problems, with lively art and music supporting the absurdity.

The full catch. Equipment conditions, arithmetic and random outcomes require thought; later characters change the rules substantially. Turn-based play is the core, but placing dice may involve dragging or other gestures worth testing. Begin with the initial character rather than treating every class or bonus episode as equally simple.

Try this first. Use the first available character and try assigning one die to one piece of equipment. Read the requirement, observe the result, and judge the placement gesture before considering a whole dungeon or a different character with an entirely new rule system.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Dice Have Better Contracts Than the Host

Dicey Dungeons put walking dice inside a peculiar game show. I immediately offered to host one in the ballroom. Mercedes asked what the contestants won.

“An unforgettable experience.” “Cash value, nigga.”

Tank held up a bread roll as his buzzer. Rosa refused to let me turn dinner into a compulsory contest. Shawna asked whether the contestants could simply play the actual game while I remained seated. A severe format revision, but the audience seemed enthusiastic.

We looked at what the dice could do in the available equipment. The ordinary act of choosing where a number belonged became more interesting than my proposed theme tune.

I rolled a hotel mint between my fingers. Tank caught it when I dropped it and said I'd lost the appetizer round. Rosa awarded him nothing because he already had dinner.

The actual dungeon show continued without any need for a rented spotlight. My contract was canceled after a pilot episode consisting entirely of people refusing the premise.

Aiden's verdict. The absurd dice-and-equipment puzzle may be a cheerful trial if the handling suits you; our live game show has failed its audience test before anybody lost dinner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer store supports characters/equipment; official project wiki describes turn-based dice allocation. Drag/hold alternatives and every episode are not verified; recommendation targets the initial character's basic loop.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/861540/>

Source 2: https://wiki.diceydungeons.com/doku.php?id=dicey_dungeons

P077 / A PLACE TO START

Balatro

Edition considered: PC base game

Turn familiar-looking poker hands into a changing score puzzle, where Jokers and modifiers can make a modest combination unexpectedly powerful.

What you do. Build a recognizable hand, read Joker effects, and select or arrange cards to improve the combination for the next scoring target.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed mouse play is declared, but scoring modifiers and boss rules add memory demands; selection and rearrangement gestures need testing.

Why it might click. Poker-like hands become ingredients in a single-player score-building puzzle, transformed by Jokers and other modifiers. The attraction is watching a modest combination become unexpectedly powerful and deciding how each new card changes the plan for the next target.

The full catch. The developer declares play without timed input and mouse-only play. Hand recognition, scoring modifiers, changing boss rules and reading several effects at once still take attention. Card rearrangement and selection need a gesture check; a familiar deck does not mean all the surrounding rules are familiar or memory-light.

Try this first. Try the opening explanation and build one clearly recognized hand. Read one Joker's effect in plain language before buying or arranging a complicated combination, then decide whether discovering the score interaction feels satisfying rather than like unwanted arithmetic homework.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Joker Knows My Entire Financial History

Balatro reached the screen while we were still inside a casino hotel, which made Darnell announce that he'd teach us all how to win money. Mercedes pointed at the game. "Different thing."

"Same instinct." "Your instinct just paid eighteen dollars for water, nigga."

I admired a Joker that changed how a familiar hand mattered. Tank admired the possibility of me finally reading the explanation instead of gambling on my personality. Shawna asked what one modifier did. We checked it together before adding another.

The pleasure was in building a score-making idea, not inviting Darnell to become our investment adviser. He attempted one more yacht comparison. Rosa asked him to carry an empty tray. He discovered an urgent call elsewhere.

I played a hand and watched the result. A small combination had become interesting through its actual effects. Behind us the casino flashed and chimed. For once I didn't need to make either kind of noise myself.

Aiden's verdict. Explore the changing combinations if score puzzles appeal; this game does not appoint the loudest yacht owner as a financial adviser, despite his persistent application.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact base listing supports poker-inspired deckbuilding, Jokers and developer-declared no timed input/Mouse Only. No real-money gambling claim or guaranteed hold-free card manipulation is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2379780/>

P078 / A PLACE TO START

Cobalt Core

Edition considered: PC release

Meet a small spaceship crew caught in a time-loop mystery, using card choices to reposition the ship as well as attack.

What you do. Inspect incoming fire, play movement or attack cards, and shift along one line to avoid shots or align weapons during encounters.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Crew decks, ship layout, and incoming fire interact; gesture comfort and the full sequence of encounters remain untested.

Why it might click. A small crew's personalities and a time-loop mystery sit inside spaceship card battles. Moving along a single line makes positioning part of the card choice: avoiding a shot or lining up a weapon can matter as much as adding more damage.

The full catch. Crew decks, ship layout, incoming fire and upgrades create interacting information to track. The publisher invites play at one's own pace, but gesture comfort and the complete sequence of encounters are not independently tested. This is a card-driven tactical game, not a reflex flying game, yet it still requires attentive planning.

Try this first. Inspect one incoming attack and one movement card during the opening guidance. See what shifting the ship changes before building a multi-card sequence, then decide whether the crew's banter gives you a reason to explore another encounter.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Our Time Loop Ends When Tank Finishes the Story

Cobalt Core had a crew caught in a time-loop mystery. Tank had a story about me losing my hotel key that he kept beginning again whenever someone new arrived.

"Nigga, they heard it." "Not from the part where you accused your own pocket."

Mercedes wanted to know how a card changed the ship's position. We watched one move and understood why location mattered. I wanted to know how to move Tank into a different conversation without wasting a friendship.

Shawna supplied the answer by asking him about his own locked-car incident. Rosa smiled immediately. The timeline developed fresh material. Tank pointed at me. "That nigga wasn't even there."

"Neither were half the people hearing my key story."

At the screen, small shifts changed what could hit whom. Around the table, one well-placed question accomplished the same thing. We laughed, then returned to the crew and its problem. My keys remained visible on the table, where history could no longer frame my trousers.

Aiden's verdict. The crew and positioning cards may make a focused, interesting combination; our local time loop has been interrupted by allowing more than one friend to be embarrassing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports card-driven single-axis combat, crew stories and playing at one's pace. No continuous-action flight claim; complete hold/gesture comfort remains unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2179850/>

P079 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wildfrost

Edition considered: PC release

Build a companion-card group in a frozen world, enjoying how a carefully chosen move can change attacks several turns into the future.

What you do. Read friendly and enemy counters, place companion cards, and choose moves that alter positioning, effects, and the order of upcoming actions.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Counters measure turns rather than seconds, but attack order and survival demand planning; card-placement comfort still needs checking.

Why it might click. Build a traveling group of companion cards in a frozen world, arranging their effects and attacks to work together. The distinctive pleasure is planning around visible action counters, so that a carefully chosen move changes what happens several turns later.

The full catch. The counters measure turns until actions, not a requirement to click within seconds. Even so, attack order, positioning, status effects and companion survival can be demanding, and a cute appearance does not predict an easy run. Card placement gestures and all-path input comfort remain checks rather than verified assurances.

Try this first. Read one friendly counter and one enemy counter, then use the opening guidance to observe what advances them. Try predicting only the next action before attempting a long chain of effects or comparing every possible leader and deck.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Frozen World Has My Ice Sculpture

Wildfrost appeared beside a melting ice sculpture I had ordered before asking what anybody wanted to look at. It was supposed to be an eagle. By dinner it looked like a wet chicken accusing me.

Tank read the delivery tag. “Nigga, you paid extra for wings.”

Rosa put a tray underneath while Mercedes studied the game's counters. Those numbers measured moves, not seconds; I didn't get to flatten every kind of pressure into the same claim. The ice, meanwhile, had a genuine relationship with real time and my carpet deposit.

Shawna asked the hotel to remove it. I tried to save the head. It detached in my hand. My wife stared at me holding a bird's slippery face in evening clothes.

“Still majestic?” she asked. “From this angle.”

Tank took one photograph before helping carry the tray. Onscreen, planning several actions ahead looked valuable. Beside it, the consequences of planning none at all dripped steadily onto my shoe.

Aiden's verdict. The companion combinations may reward planning around turn counters; the only unavoidable countdown in our immediate surroundings belonged to my increasingly liquid attempt at grandeur.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher explicitly explains turn-based battles and counters measured in turns. This distinguishes counters from real-time deadlines; no low-difficulty or hold-free promise is inferred from visual style.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1811990/>

P080 / A PLACE TO START

Clubhouse Games: 51 Worldwide Classics

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch; individual games must be assessed separately

Find one enjoyable little ritual within a collection of distinct board, card, and other games, each offering its own in-game explanation.

What you do. Start with Four in a Row, read that game's instructions, and test selecting and placing a piece in the chosen player setup.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Assess each game separately: the collection includes reflex games, and multiplayer, touch, motion, and undo options vary by title.

Why it might click. The collection offers many small, distinct games with in-game explanations, from familiar boards to cards and more active diversions. Its useful promise is variety within one package: it may be possible to find one pleasing little ritual without adopting a long campaign.

The full catch. Assess individual games, not the collection as one control profile. Nintendo explicitly distinguishes strategic choices such as Four-in-a-row from reflex games such as Slot Cars and Toy Boxing. Multiplayer, motion, touch and undo availability vary by game. Shared competitive play is not automatically cooperative play.

Try this first. Open Four-in-a-row and read its own instructions, then test selecting and placing a piece in a local or solo arrangement without an added household timer. Check that game's controls and player setup before trying a second title.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Fifty-One Games and I Pick the One With Four Pieces

Clubhouse Games gave us a whole collection. I started explaining that our first trial concerned one specific game within it. Shawna nodded. "Four in a Row." I was almost disappointed she'd read the note before my performance.

Tank sat opposite me. Rosa put a small plate between us. Mercedes asked whether the rest of the collection would remain available later. Of course. Nobody had to swallow the whole menu to enjoy one thing.

Dre set his blue controller down and watched my first move. "You sure?" "Completely." "All right, my nigga." A deeply unhelpful tone from a man holding the correct casserole lid.

A few moves later Tank won. I requested an explanation. He pointed at four pieces. I requested a rematch. Shawna offered me a choice: another game or a dance.

I stood. Tank smiled. "Tactical withdrawal."

"Romance," I said. My wife pulled me toward the music before the losing commander could hold a press conference.

Aiden's verdict. Start with the named Four in a Row trial rather than treating all fifty-one games alike; my first defeat has produced a perfectly respectable alternative evening activity.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms collection/tutorials and explicitly separates strategic/reflex games; proposed trial is Four-in-a-row only. Collection-level mixed pace/input must not certify every included game. Native co-op scope and game-specific holds are unverified.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/clubhouse-games-51-worldwide-classics-switch/>

Four in a Row and One Dance Owed

Tank beat me at Four in a Row and waited for the appeal. I inspected the pieces. Four of his, visibly together, with no constitutional ambiguity I could exploit. Dre leaned over and counted them aloud. Slowly. “Nigga, I can count,” I said. “Then this will be quick.” It was. I had lost a game, which appeared to be survivable despite the enthusiastic audience.

Shawna offered me a dance instead of a rematch. I took it before my mouth found a reason to summon a tournament committee. The music came from Mercedes's chosen playlist now. She had finished checking the recording and wanted to eat, laugh, and hear somebody else for a while. We gave her that. Porsche tucked the equipment bag beside her own chair. Darnell asked whether he could play one track from his yacht. Every woman within hearing distance said no at a slightly different pitch. Briefly, the room became a choir.

My wife moved close. “How are the trousers?” “Diplomatically sound.” “Good. I was worried about a border incident.” I laughed against her hair. We danced without a camera crew clearing space, without a special introduction, without the throne identifying who was important. Tank filmed three seconds, saw Shawna shake her head, and put his phone down. Some moments were better when everybody in them could remain there.

The hotel manager waited until the song ended before handing me the final additions. A considerate executioner. I read them properly this time. Asked about one duplicated charge. He checked and removed it. Paid the rest. No empire collapsed; no bank sent a helicopter. It was just money leaving because I had agreed to spend it. Mercedes watched from her chair. “Look at this nigga learning a plot with consequences.” I bowed. The new trousers held. We took that as a second victory.

Rosa gave the remaining staff food to take home. She checked who wanted what instead of packaging everybody the same meal. Tank carried the boxes to the back, returned with the empty trolley, and asked whether we were done moving things. I looked at the mechanical throne. He followed my gaze. “No.” “The crew will collect it.” “Correct answer, my nigga.” We left the enormous chair where the rental company could reclaim both its motors and my ambitions.

Dre found the lid for his casserole and offered the last portion around before closing it. Darnell had finally stopped talking about the yacht because the bartender had gone on break. The sponsor sat with a small game open, quietly reading a choice instead of trying to become part of Mercedes's recording. I considered this proof that everyone had grown. Shawna said it might only prove we were tired. Both explanations allowed sitting down, so I accepted the more modest one without a fight.

There were games people wanted to revisit and games nobody wanted to touch. Nobody owed the room a reason that satisfied me. Heavy systems could be the pleasure, or they could be an obstacle. A little card puzzle could catch somebody completely. A huge famous story could leave them cold. The important answer was the one they actually felt while playing, not the answer that made my purchase sound wise. Tank pointed at the throne. “Same with chairs.” I told him he'd made the point. He said the chair had helped.

Mercedes stood and hugged me. “Good night, Aiden.” I asked whether she'd enjoyed herself. “Parts.” “Which parts?” She looked toward the screen, the food, Shawna, and the friends still talking. Then she looked at me. “You were in some of them.” Nigga, I nearly ruined that by asking for a percentage. Instead I hugged her back and thanked her for singing. No sponsor language. No review. Just what I meant.

When we left, I carried Shawna's shoes. Tank carried Rosa's bag. Porsche carried the recording because Mercedes had asked her to. Dre carried the casserole. Everybody had something whose destination they understood. The throne stayed behind. So did the statue, the unused light, and the face on the board, which the hotel had turned gently toward the wall. My wife leaned against me in the lift. “What did we learn?” she asked. I looked at her shoes in my hand. “I should buy looser trousers.” She laughed and kissed me. For tonight, nigga, that answer was enough.

Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Tellings Cut: original revised Panorama prose and production by ChatGPT; original game research and selection system retained. This is a separate adult comic companion to Ten Toes Down. Source novels and the first Panorama edition remain intact. All people participating in the fictional party scenes are adults; Lillian is addressed as the reader.

Voice sources sampled for this revision: the Niggatorial Tellings Book I funeral and first Vegas party, selected passages from Books II-VI, and the edition editorial record. Source repository Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down; working base 4cdof7a6e36977ff0ac705a59ebe65407d1f2bee. Selected passages were read closely; no full reread of all six novels is claimed. The added game-night story is newly composed fiction.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This adult comic edition includes frequent reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine and party references, sexual banter and non-graphic innuendo. Those scenes are separate from the factual game descriptions and are not descriptions of the developers or real readers.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.